



UNLOCKING PRODUCT INNOVATION FROM THE INSIDE

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Table of Contents

4 Strategic Habits	4
User Experience Briefing	12
Framestorming	30
OKR Stories	48
Market Validation Playbook	60
SxD (Strategy by Design) Prioritization Method	70

4 STRATEGIC HABITS

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Getting Innovation into Projects

4 Strategic Habits

In most organizations, innovation isn't blocked by a lack of ideas. It is blocked by how projects are framed, prioritized, and executed.

These four strategic habits help product managers, design leaders, and cross-functional teams create the conditions for innovation to succeed inside the constraints of real-world delivery. Use them to unlock higher-quality outcomes, deeper alignment, and sustained momentum across your work.

Question the Problem

Innovation starts with better questions, not better ideas.

Innovation often fails before it starts, not because people lack creativity, but because the project is built on a narrow or tactical framing.

Most initiatives begin with a symptom: a performance issue, a drop in usage, or a customer complaint. If we accept the problem

statement as it is, we may end up solving the wrong thing, or solving the right thing in a shallow way.

This is where design leaders and product managers have a unique opportunity. The UX Brief provides a structured way to reframe the challenge by asking key strategic questions:

- Who are we really designing for?
- What unmet needs can we address?
- Where could we have the greatest impact?

For product managers, these questions are part of sound planning.

For designers, they fit naturally within the design process.

But in truth, they reframe the foundation of the entire strategy.

By asking them through the lens of UX, we avoid stepping on toes while setting the stage for more meaningful innovation.

Goal:

Earn access and influence by clarifying what is unclear, together.

Tools:

User Research, UX Brief, Framestorming

STRATEGIC HABIT 2

Use a Specific Project to Solve for the System

Use one project to uncover insights that benefit the whole.

Every product lives inside a system—a customer journey, a value chain, a shared technical stack. But most teams only get permission to work on one small slice.

That is your opportunity.

Use the scope you have been given to explore the bigger picture. When you conduct user research or map journeys, do it in a way that

reveals patterns across products and touchpoints. When you model value propositions, tie them to shared needs and behaviors, not just isolated features.

This is systems thinking, financed by a single project.

If done well, the artifacts you create will not just solve today's task. They will become strategic assets, reused by other teams, informing future projects, and evolving into long-term standards.

Goal:

Turn local insight into system-level clarity. Make one project do the work of many.

Tools:

Journey Mapping, Value Proposition Modeling, Service Blueprinting

STRATEGIC HABIT 3

Prioritize with Discipline

Use a structured approach to make prioritization repeatable, transparent, and tied to outcomes.

Most organizations say they want innovation, but prioritize based on gut feeling, seniority, or what feels safest.

To consistently drive innovation, we need a shared and evidence-based approach to prioritization. That means:

- Connecting ideas to customer and business

outcomes

- Making trade-offs visible and discussable
- Creating space for bold, strategic bets, not just easy wins

Structured Prioritization is a repeatable practice, not a one-time task. It leads to better conversations, more predictable outcomes, and a clearer understanding of why we are building what we are building.

Goal:

Replace opinion-driven decisions with a shared, repeatable practice.

Tools:

SxD Prioritization

STRATEGIC HABIT 4

Align and Adapt Continuously

Keep teams focused on the goal while giving them tools to adjust with purpose.

Even well-prioritized, well-framed projects can drift off course.

Features get added without reassessing the goal. New leaders shift direction. Teams forget

why they started or who they are building for.

To protect innovation through delivery, teams need rhythm and reference points. OKRs and customer insights provide both. They anchor the team to a shared intent and make it easier to adapt thoughtfully when things change.

This is not about locking in a fixed plan. It

Goal:

Stay aligned on intent while adapting to new information.

Tools:

OKR Stories

USER EXPERIENCE BRIEFING

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Purpose and How to Use This Guide

Crafting intelligent design solutions for lasting impact.

This guide is designed to support the early-stage conversations that shape any successful product development effort. It provides a structured way to align across teams such as Product, UX, Engineering, and Strategy before moving into solution mode. The questions help clarify purpose, priorities, and constraints so the team can make better decisions with greater confidence.

While the guide originates from a user-centered design perspective, it is not intended for UX professionals alone. It reflects the belief that strong products are built when user insight, technical feasibility, and business strategy are considered together from the outset. UX is not a downstream task. It is a critical part of defining what to build and why.

Use this guide to support discovery sessions, kickoff meetings, or one-on-one conversations. It is not a checklist to fill out. Instead, treat it as a framework for asking the right questions, identifying gaps in knowledge, and starting with alignment.

What's in the Guide

The guide is organized into seven sections that cover the most important questions to ask before committing to a solution:

- 1. Who Are We Designing For?**
Define the users, segments, and stakeholders we're solving for.
- 2. What Unmet Needs Can We Address?**
Identify user pain points, goals, and jobs to be done.
- 3. Where Do We Want to Play?**
Clarify the strategic focus, market context, and usage environment.
- 4. Why Are We Uniquely Qualified?**
Articulate our differentiation and the capabilities we bring.
- 5. How Will We Measure Success?**
Align on intended outcomes and how we'll know we're making progress.
- 6. What Constraints and Requirements Exist?**
Ensure shared understanding of technical, legal, and organizational boundaries.
- 7. How Will We Work Together?**
Establish clear expectations for collaboration and decision-making.

Each section includes guiding questions and, where relevant, recommended methods for filling in knowledge gaps before moving forward.

Section 1: Who Are We Designing For?

Define the core users, stakeholders, and segments involved in or affected by the product.

Primary Users

- Who are the end users of this product or service?
- Are they individuals, teams, organizations—or a mix?
- What roles or job functions do they have?
- What makes these users important to focus on?

Segments & Personas

- Have we identified any user segments (e.g., by behavior, mindset, or unmet needs)?
- Do we already use personas or archetypes to describe them?
- Which segments are most strategically important or underserved?
- Are there critical differences in goals, context, or motivation across segments?

Context of Use

- In what situations do users interact with our product?
- Where are they?
- What devices or tools are they using?
- Are they focused, distracted, under pressure?
- What other tools or processes do they rely on before, during, or after using our product?
- Are there any accessibility needs or environmental constraints we should understand?

Influencers & Stakeholders

- Besides end users, who else influences the success of the experience?
 - Managers or team leads
 - IT or procurement
 - Regulators or partners
 - Buyers
- What do we know about their expectations, goals, or constraints?

Methods to Address Critical Unknowns

If critical gaps or assumptions are uncovered, consider the following methods to better understand your users.

Customer Journey Mapping

Map key moments, pain points, and system touchpoints to visualize the full user experience.

Field Studies / Contextual Inquiry

Observe users in their actual environment to understand behavior and context.

Diary Studies / Experience Sampling

Let users document their experiences over time to surface routines, frustrations, and needs.

Segmentation Analysis

Use qualitative and quantitative data to define user groups based on behavior, mindset, or task orientation.

Persona Development Workshop

Align the team around evidence-based personas that represent real user patterns.

Section 2: What Unmet Needs Can We Address?

Identify key user problems, jobs to be done, and moments of opportunity.

User Needs & Pain Points

- What key problems or frustrations are users currently experiencing?
- What's holding them back from achieving their goals?
- Are these problems functional, emotional, or social in nature?

Tasks & Jobs to Be Done

- What are users trying to accomplish when they turn to us?
- Where do current tools, systems, or processes fall short?
- Are there recurring workarounds, hacks, or unmet expectations?

Journey & Moments That Matter

- Where are the critical moments of friction, confusion, or hesitation?
- Are there high-effort steps in the current user journey?
- Are there moments where we could create disproportionate value?

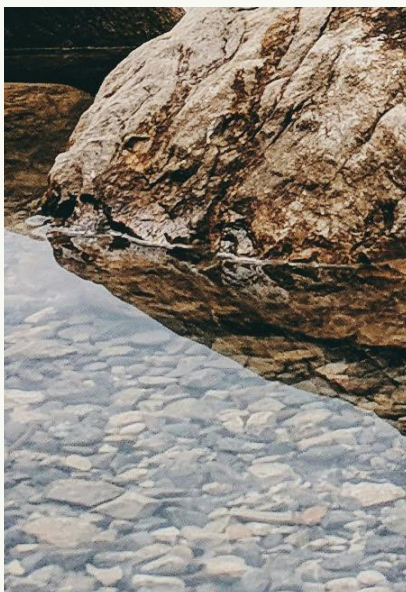
Knowns and Unknowns

- Which unmet needs are well understood?
- Where are we relying on assumptions?
- What do we need to validate before moving forward?



Methods to Address Critical Unknowns

If we need to learn more about user needs, consider:



Customer Journey Mapping

Identify pain points and gaps across the experience.

User Research & Usability Testing

Explore goals, expectations, and behavior in context.

Jobs-to-be-Done Interviews

Reveal motivations and desired outcomes behind tasks.

Support Log Analysis

Uncover frequently reported issues or patterns.

Internal Interviews

Gather insights from sales, support, or training teams.

Section 3: Where Do We Want to Play?

Clarify the market space, ecosystem boundaries, and focus of this initiative.

Market and Category

- What type of market or category does this product operate in?
- Are we entering an existing market, creating a new one, or repositioning within a current space?
- What adjacent products or services overlap or compete with this one?

Competitors and Alternatives

- What other solutions do users currently turn to?
- What are we replacing, competing with, or improving upon?
- Are there clear points of comparison from the user's perspective?

Context of Use

- Where and when will this product be used?
- What devices, tools, or channels are involved?
- Are there specific settings or environments we must consider?

Strategic Scope and Focus

- Are we targeting a specific geography, industry, or use case?
- What are we intentionally leaving out of scope for now?
- What is the first segment, market, or application we want to win?

Knowns and Unknowns

- What aspects of our intended market and usage context are well understood?
- Where are we making assumptions about our fit or focus?
- What needs to be validated to avoid misalignment or wasted effort?

Methods to Address Critical Unknowns

If there are open questions about our playing field, consider:

SWOT

Identify internal strengths and weaknesses relative to external opportunities and threats

Invaluable Proposition

Frame where we deliver unique value within the market

Framestorming

Explore different perspectives on what problem we're solving and how it's framed

Competitive Benchmarking

Compare features, UX, positioning, and business models

Section 4: Why Are We Uniquely Qualified?

Define what makes us the right team or company to solve this problem, and how we are different.

Differentiation

- What makes us different from other solutions in the market?
- What can we do that others can't—or haven't?
- Why would users or buyers choose us over alternatives?

Knowns and Unknowns

- What parts of our advantage are validated and well understood?
- Where are we overstating or assuming our differentiation?
- What gaps exist in our ability to deliver or scale this solution?

Strategic Fit

- How does this initiative align with our broader business goals or platform strategy?
- Is this product part of a larger vision, ecosystem, or roadmap?
- What long-term position or role are we aiming to play in the market?

Capabilities and Assets

- What internal capabilities give us an advantage?
- What tools, systems, partnerships, IP, or proprietary tech can we leverage?
- Do we have unique access to customers, data, or domain expertise?



Methods to Address Critical Unknowns

If our strengths or strategic positioning are unclear, consider:



Invaluable Proposition

Clarify what makes our offer valuable, credible, and differentiated

SWOT

Surface capabilities and constraints relative to competitors and the market

Strategy Stack

Ensure alignment across layers of brand, value proposition, delivery, and operating model
Internal

Capability Mapping

Identify assets, expertise, and infrastructure already in place

Stakeholder Workshops

Align internal understanding of value, fit, and strategic relevance

Section 5: How Will We Measure Success?

Define the outcomes we care about, how we'll measure them, and what success looks like, both for users and the business.

User Outcomes

- What user behaviors or changes will indicate that we're delivering value?
- What should users be able to do faster, easier, or more confidently?
- Are there specific signals of satisfaction, trust, or engagement?

Business Outcomes

- What business results should this initiative drive?
- Are we aiming for increased revenue, reduced cost, higher retention, or something else?
- How does this fit into broader company or product OKRs?

Key Metrics

- What metrics or KPIs will we use to track progress?
- Are there both leading indicators (early signals) and lagging indicators (long-term impact)?
- What targets or benchmarks are important for internal stakeholders?

Success Criteria

- What would “wild success” look like for this product?
- What's the minimum outcome that would still be considered a win?
- What does failure look like—and how will we recognize early warning signs?

Knowns and Unknowns

- Which success factors are already being tracked or benchmarked?
- Where are we unclear about how to measure impact?
- What assumptions are we making about what users or the business will value?

Methods to Address Critical Unknowns

If outcomes or metrics are unclear, consider:

OKR Stories

Define measurable goals tied to strategic outcomes

Market Commitment Validation

Test whether users are willing to act, pay, or change behavior

Metrics Mapping Workshop

Align stakeholders on meaningful and actionable indicators

Product Analytics Review

Audit existing tracking to identify coverage and gaps

Section 6: What Constraints and Requirements Exist?

Identify the boundaries that shape what's possible—technical, legal, operational, and organizational.

Technical Constraints

- What existing systems, architecture, or platforms must we work within?
- Are there known limitations related to performance, security, scalability, or legacy infrastructure?
- Are we tied to any specific devices, APIs, environments, or development frameworks?

Legal, Regulatory, and Compliance Requirements

- Are there legal standards we must meet (e.g., data privacy, accessibility, medical compliance)?
- What industry-specific regulations apply to this product?
- Do we need legal, procurement, or risk review at certain stages?

Timeline and Resources

- What is the timeline for delivery or major milestones?
- Are there fixed deadlines we must hit (e.g., market launches, internal reviews, partner dependencies)?
- What is our available budget, team capacity, or vendor support?

Organizational Dependencies

- Are there other teams, products, or stakeholders this project depends on, or who depend on us?
- Are there known integration points, shared services, or collaboration challenges?
- What is the approval process for changes or final decisions?

Knowns and Unknowns

- Which constraints are clearly documented and agreed upon?
- Where are we assuming flexibility that might not exist?
- Are there risks we haven't yet addressed?



Methods to Address Critical Unknowns

If key constraints are unclear or unstable, consider:

SxD Prioritization

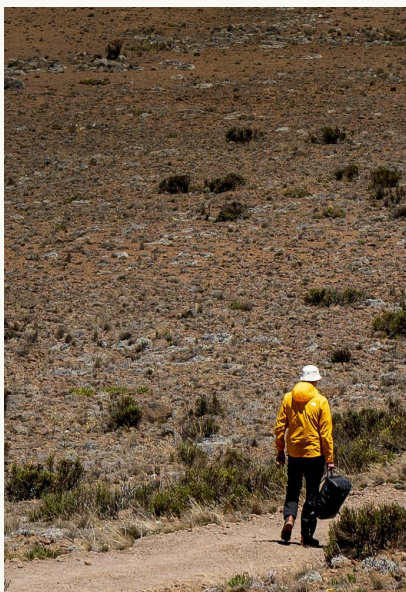
Evaluate trade-offs between impact, effort, and feasibility

Compliance and Risk Review

Bring in legal or security experts early to validate assumptions

Technical Discovery Workshop

Clarify integration points, system constraints, and edge cases



Section 7: How Will We Work Together?

Establish expectations for collaboration, decision-making, and the working process.

Team and Stakeholders

- Who are the core team members for this project?
- What roles do each of them play in shaping, approving, or executing the work?
- Who needs to be informed, consulted, or brought in at key moments?

Cadence and Communication

- What is our working rhythm—e.g., weekly check-ins, design reviews, product demos?
- What tools and channels will we use to stay in sync (e.g., Slack, Jira, Miro, Notion)?
- Are there existing rituals we need to align with?

Process and Phases

- What are the expected phases for research, design, prototyping, development, and testing?
- Do we have flexibility for iterative cycles, or is the schedule fixed?
- Where does validation or user feedback fit into the timeline?

Decision-Making

- Who has the final say on product, design, or technical decisions?
- What is the process for reviewing and approving work?
- How will we handle disagreements or scope changes?

Feedback and Adaptation

- How will feedback from users or stakeholders be captured and acted on?
- How will we know if we're getting off track?
- What's our plan if priorities shift?

Knowns and Unknowns

- What aspects of team setup and process are already defined?
- Where are we assuming alignment or clarity that doesn't exist yet?
- What gaps might slow us down or create confusion?

Methods to Address Critical Unknowns

If collaboration structure is unclear or misaligned, consider:

Strategy Communication

Align goals, roles, and expectations across layers

Kickoff Workshop

Clarify team norms, scope, milestones, and working agreements

RACI Mapping

Define who is Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, and Informed

Design Sprint

Build shared understanding and alignment quickly through hands-on collaboration Framestorming – Use reframing techniques to align on purpose and process before execution

Methods Referenced in This Guide

This guide includes a wide range of methods to help teams answer critical questions, especially when assumptions or gaps emerge during early conversations. Some of these methods are part of the Strategy by Design (SxD) framework, while others come from broader UX, research, and product practice. The goal is not to prescribe a process, but to equip teams with proven ways to gain clarity before moving forward. Use these methods selectively, based on what's most important to validate or explore at each stage.

SxD Framework Methods

- Invaluable Proposition
- Strategy Stack
- SxD Prioritization
- OKR Stories
- Market Commitment Validation
- Framestorming
- Strategy Communication

Additional Methods

User Research & Discovery

- Field Studies / Contextual Inquiry
- Diary Studies / Experience Sampling
- Segmentation Analysis
- Persona Development Workshop
- User Research & Usability Testing
- Jobs-to-be-Done Interviews
- Support Log Analysis
- Internal Interviews

Market & Ecosystem Strategy

- SWOT
- Competitive Benchmarking
- Ecosystem Mapping

Organizational & Capability Assessment

- Capability Mapping
- Stakeholder Workshops

Metrics & Performance

- Metrics Mapping Workshop
- Product Analytics Review

Risk & Technical Readiness

- Compliance and Risk Review
- Technical Discovery Workshop

Team Alignment & Ways of Working

- Kickoff Workshop
- RACI Mapping
- Design Sprint



FRAME- STORMING

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Reframe Challenges Before Solving Them

The better you define the problem to solve the better the solution.

Framestorming is a structured method for exploring different ways to frame a problem before jumping into solution mode. While brainstorming focuses on generating ideas within a given frame, framestorming challenges the frame itself:

- Are we solving the right problem?
- Is there a better way to define this challenge?

By surfacing alternative perspectives, framestorming helps teams escape narrow thinking, uncover hidden assumptions, and identify more impactful opportunities.

Why Framestorm Instead of Just Brainstorm?

The trigger is often not the problem

Most projects begin with a problem statement, but that statement is often based on a symptom, internal demand, or technical trigger. If the framing is off, then even brilliant solutions may miss the mark.

As the saying goes: *Fall in love with the problem, not the solution.*

When teams anchor themselves to a truly meaningful problem, they unlock more than a product. They unlock a roadmap. A well-framed problem can guide innovation for years. But that only happens when we challenge our first assumptions and reframe the challenge with care.

The Impact of Framestorming

Most product teams face a fundamental constraint: There are never enough developers, designers, or product managers to pursue every good idea.

Framestorming ensures that limited resources are used where they matter most. Instead of reacting to surface-level issues or defaulting to stakeholder demands, teams take a step back to ask: Is this really the best use of our time and talent?

It helps teams:

1. **Avoid waste** by not solving the wrong problem
2. **Maximize impact** by aligning effort with the most meaningful opportunities
3. **Reveal leverage points** where small investments can create large returns
4. **Focus resources** on the right challenge for the right duration—no more, no less

The goal isn't just to solve problems—it's to make sure you're solving the **right** problem with the **right** level of investment. Framestorming gives you a better chance of hitting that sweet spot where strategy, execution, and value converge.

Examples of Reframing in Action

Framestorming can sound abstract, but its power becomes clear when you see how a small shift in framing leads to radically different outcomes.

NASA vs. the Pencil

NASA once faced a challenge: how could astronauts write in zero gravity? A contractor invested heavily in developing a space pen. Meanwhile, the Russian space agency used pencils.

While more parable than fact, this story captures a core truth:

Sometimes the real innovation comes not from solving the problem as defined, but from questioning whether it needs to be solved at all.

Reframing the Cure for Cancer

A team is tasked with “finding a cure for cancer.” Through framestorming, they explore alternate frames:

- **Prevent it** – Focus on early detection and education
- **Improve quality of life** – Support patients in living well with the disease

Each frame leads to different strategies and timelines, ranging from breakthrough R&D (Horizon 3) to low-hanging improvements (Horizon 1).

When Should You Use Framestorming?

5 situations to look out for

- At the start of a project, to clarify the challenge
- When a team feels stuck in narrow thinking
- After a failed solution to revisit the original assumptions
- During strategy discussions or innovation sprints
- In retros or discovery phases, to make space for critical reflection

Preparing to Reframe: The Triangulation Phase

3 perspectives

Before you start reframing a challenge, it's essential to ground your team in three core perspectives:

- User Needs
- Business Goals
- Technical Opportunities and Constraints

Together, these lenses ensure the team doesn't just respond to the trigger, but sees the full strategic landscape.

1. Understand User Needs (UX Briefing)

Use a UX Briefing to align around:

- Who we're designing for (users, segments, stakeholders)
- What unmet needs and pain points exist
- Where the product fits into the broader user journey
- Where assumptions or knowledge gaps remain

This step ensures the problem is seen through the eyes of those most affected.

2. Align on Business Goals and Strategic Intent

Clarify:

- What business outcomes we're aiming for (e.g., growth, retention, cost reduction)
- How does this initiative support strategic objectives or OKRs
- What success looks like for the business
- What constraints (timeline, brand, politics) may influence decisions

This can raise the ambition of the work by integrating broader goals into reframing.

3. Clarify Technical Constraints and Opportunities

Identify:

- Relevant platforms, systems, dependencies, and tech debt
- Emerging tech that could unlock new solutions
- Limitations or risks to consider
- Enabling capabilities that could support a higher-leverage approach

Even a light discovery session can prevent blind spots and open up new possibilities.

Why the Preparation Pays Off

This work creates a reusable foundation:

- Easier to reframe consistently across projects
- Faster onboarding of new teams or stakeholders
- Simplifies the spotting of adjacent opportunities
- Aligns business, design, and tech from day one

How to Run a Framestorming Session

Once you've completed the preparation phase, use this guide to facilitate the reframing conversation.

Estimated total time: 90–120 minutes

Step 1: Establish the Starting Point (10–25 minutes)

Begin by briefly sharing the current problem framing as defined by the sponsor, stakeholder, or initiating team. This should be no more than a sentence or two, just enough to ground the team in what prompted the session.

Then, the facilitator presents a concise summary of key insights from the Triangulation Phase:

- What we know about users and their needs
- Business goals and success metrics
- Relevant technical constraints or enablers

This provides shared context for the team and sets up a more informed reframing process.

Step 2: Explore Alternative Frames (25–35 minutes)

This step is about identifying the most impactful problem the team could be solving—whether that means reframing the original challenge or expanding it to include adjacent issues that deliver greater value.

You’ve already reviewed the original framing and examined user, business, and technical insights during the Triangulation Phase. Now it’s time to use that broader perspective to explore how the challenge could be seen differently.

2.1. Generate Alternative Frames (15 minutes)

The team is now going to challenge the current framing.

This is where the shift happens—from passive acceptance to active reframing. Invite each participant to write down as many alternative problem frames as they can, using one sticky note per idea (physical or digital). Encourage quantity over quality. Some frames may build on the original; others may redefine it entirely. Both are valuable.

The facilitator can guide the group by drawing from the following lenses:

General

- Are we focusing on the most impactful problem?
- Is there a related or adjacent issue that matters more?
- Could we expand the scope to include a second-tier problem that adds value?
- Are we addressing a symptom when a deeper cause might be more worth solving?

User & Customer

- What do we know about what users are trying to do?
- What's being overlooked?
- How would they describe the issue?

Technology

- Are we framing the problem around a constraint we could redesign?
- Could emerging tech open new possibilities?

Business

- Does the current frame align with how we create value?
- Could another frame reveal a more scalable or strategic opportunity?

Regulatory & Compliance

- Is this a real constraint—or just an assumed one?
- Could we reframe to meet both policy and user needs?

Encourage the group to consider both short-term and long-term possibilities. Some frames may suggest quick wins, others adjacent opportunities, and a few might hint at transformational change. Don't worry about sorting them yet—many of the strongest frames will naturally span multiple time horizons.

2.2. Vote and Discuss (10–20 minutes)

Once a broad set of alternative frames has been generated, invite the group to dot vote on the ones they find most compelling, surprising, or strategically promising.

After voting, facilitate a focused discussion around the top-voted frames:

- What makes these frames resonate?
- Do they suggest a better use of our limited resources?
- Could they lead to greater impact for the user, business, or system?

This conversation isn't about choosing a single winner. The goal is to surface 2–3 reframed challenges that feel more meaningful or generative than the original. These frames will guide the next phase of exploration—whether that's ideation, discovery work, or strategic alignment.

Step 3: Group and Explore Patterns (20–30 minutes)

Now that you've generated and discussed a wide range of alternative frames, it's time to make sense of the patterns. Step 3 helps the team identify which frames stand out and explore how the most promising ones could evolve over time. This isn't just about picking favorites; it's about recognizing strategic depth and surfacing frames that offer both immediate and long-term value.

3.1 Cluster related frames and name the clusters (8–10 minutes)

Work together to group similar frames—those that focus on similar aspects of the problem or point toward related areas of opportunity. These might center around users, internal processes, business challenges, or system-level dynamics.

Once grouped, assign a short, descriptive name to each cluster. This makes it easier to talk about them in the next steps and reveals emerging themes in the team's thinking.

3.2 Dot vote to find the most promising frames (5–8 minutes)

Invite the group to dot vote on the individual frames or clusters that feel most promising, surprising, or strategically important. After voting, take a moment to rank the top 3–5 and briefly discuss why they stood out:

- What makes them feel important?
- Do they unlock greater impact?
- Are they timely or underexplored?

3.3 Choose top 1–2 frames and map across time horizons(8–12 minutes)

Select one or two of the most promising frames or clusters. As a group, explore how these could evolve over time:

- What does this look like as a **quick win** or **incremental improvement** (Horizon 1)?
- How might it grow into a **mid-term strategic initiative** or **adjacent opportunity** (Horizon 2)?
- What would the **long-term, transformational version** of this problem/solution look like (Horizon 3)?

You're not categorizing the problem into a horizon—you're exploring how it might **expand** across all three.

This perspective helps the team understand the **strategic flexibility** and **scalability** of the most valuable frames.

Step 4: Select and Activate Strategic Frames (15–20 min)

You've explored a range of frames and surfaced the most promising ones. Now it's time to commit to a small set that will guide next steps—and turn insight into action.

4.1 Refine Top Frames (5–10 minutes)

Choose 1–2 frames that feel especially:

- Rich in insight
- Aligned with unmet needs or strategic opportunity
- Likely to broaden the solution space

Rewrite each one clearly and succinctly. Aim for phrasing that:

- Highlights the core tension or opportunity
- Is inspiring, not overly constrained
- Is easy to share and build on

Example:

Instead of “Improve onboarding emails,”

Use: “How might we help users feel momentum within the first 10 minutes?”

4.2 Choose a Strategic Path Forward (5–10 minutes)

As a team, decide how to activate the selected frames. Options include:

- **Ideation** – Run a focused brainstorm to explore solutions
- **Research** – Identify assumptions and knowledge gaps to test
- **Strategic discussion** – Bring reframed problems into roadmap or OKR planning
- **Alignment** – Share with stakeholders to realign goals or metrics

Choose one or two immediate next actions. Assign an owner to follow up.

Framestorming Tips for Facilitators

- **Create psychological safety** – Invite doubt. Celebrate provocative frames.
- **Don't evaluate too early** – Defer judgment until after divergent thinking.
- **Model curiosity** – Ask “What else could this be?”
- **Watch for solution bias** – Refocus on reframing if ideas dominate too soon.
- **Use timeboxes** – 15–30 minutes is often enough to unlock better thinking.

Common Pitfalls to Avoid

- Jumping to solutions before questioning the framing
- Rewriting the original frame slightly instead of truly challenging it
- Confusing stakeholder goals with user problems
- Treating framestorming as a one-off exercise rather than a recurring tool

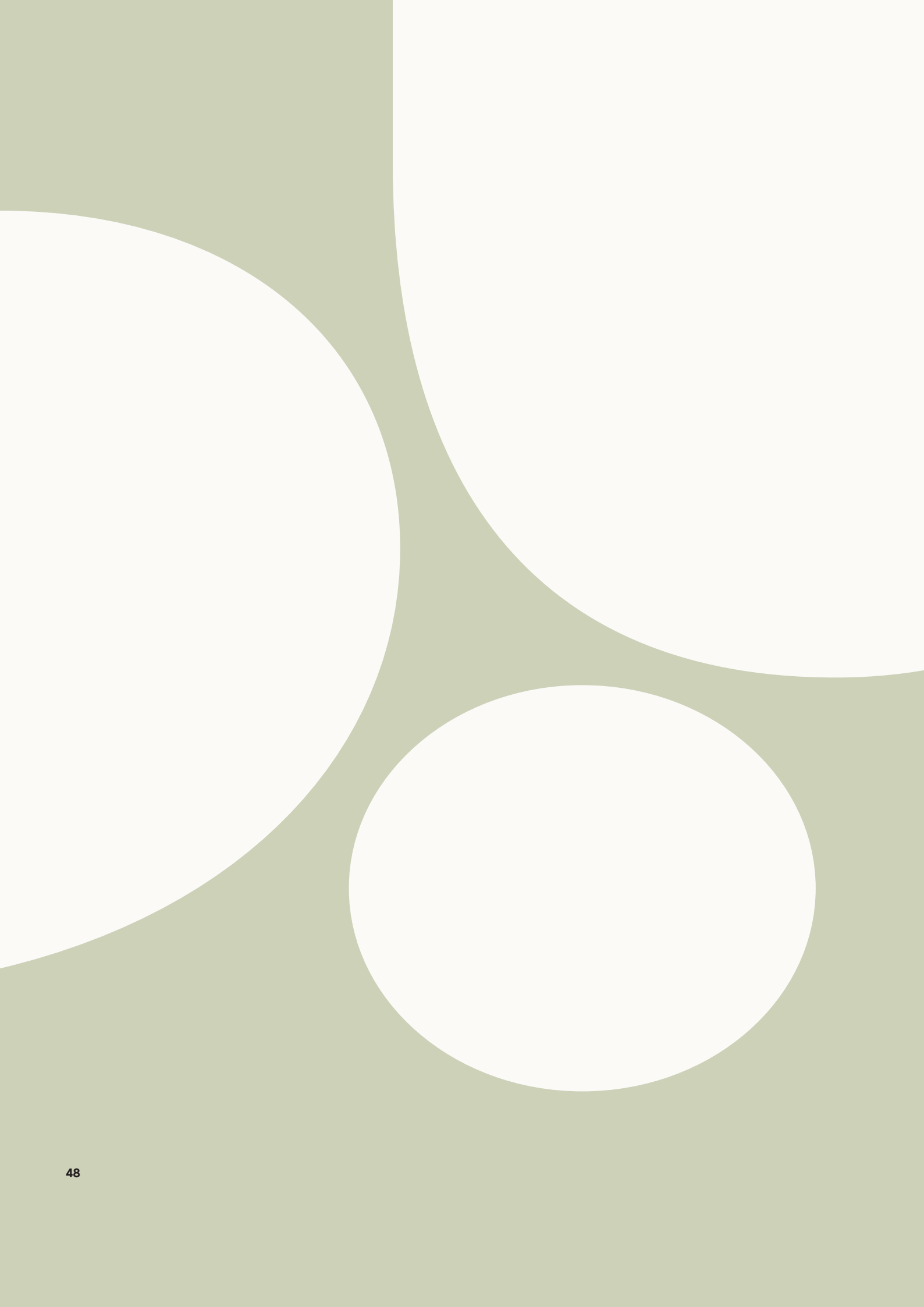
Conclusion

Framestorming is a high-leverage method for teams who want to solve meaningful problems, not just the ones handed to them. When combined with strategic preparation, it ensures that effort and insight are directed where they matter most.

Use it early. Use it often. Use it when you're stuck.

And above all:

Fall in love with the problem,
not the solution.



OKR STORIES

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OKR Stories: Making Strategy Relatable and Actionable

Why Traditional OKRs Fall Short

Objectives and Key Results (OKRs) are widely used for setting ambitious goals and tracking progress. Yet, many organizations struggle with OKRs because they often feel disconnected from real impact. Employees may see them as

arbitrary numbers rather than meaningful drivers of change. Without a clear narrative, OKRs can become dry metrics instead of inspiring objectives that align and motivate teams.

This is where OKR Stories come in.

What Are OKR Stories?

OKR Stories combine the structured goal-setting of OKRs with the vision-driven storytelling of Product Narratives. Instead of just listing an Objective and Key Results, an OKR Story frames the purpose/vision as a narrative, explaining how the work will improve customers' lives. This approach helps teams understand not just what they need to achieve, but why it matters.

Create a Product Narrative to Drive Effective OKRs

At the heart of every great product innovation is a clear, compelling story. Not just a story about features, but a story about a real human problem and how the product transforms that situation.

The Blackberry story isn't about wireless email or device specs. It's about **Jon Klein**, a C-level executive who felt disconnected, overwhelmed, and out of control during the workday. That emotional insight—"he felt left out, **uninformed, out of control**"—became the **anchor for Blackberry's strategy**.

The narrative forced the team at RIM to define:

- **Who** they were solving for
- **What** the pain was
- **Why** it mattered
- **How** their product would create change

That's exactly what a good OKR should do.

But too often, OKRs skip straight to numbers: "reduce support ticket backlog," "increase engagement," "shorten delivery time." Without a narrative, these sound like chores, not missions.

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A clear
narrative
shows
why a goal
matters, so
teams can
contribute

The OKR Story Development Process

Developing an effective OKR Story is a structured process that ensures objectives are clear, impactful, and actionable.

Step 1: Define the Future Narrative (Vision) & User Perspective

Before building OKRs, start with a clear and compelling reason for the goal to exist. Use the Invaluable Proposition framework to define what makes the goal matter to users, not just the business.

This step ensures your objective is worth pursuing by anchoring it in real user problems, validated needs, and a clear future benefit.

To develop a powerful narrative:

- **Identify the unique value** this goal delivers to users
What makes it different or better than alternatives?
- **Clarify who it's for** and what problem it solves
Who benefits most? What's broken or frustrating in their world?
- **Describe the desired future state**
What will change for the user if we succeed?

Step 2: Storyboarding your Product Narrative

Once you've defined the value, turn it into a story your team can align around. A strong Product Narrative explains who it's for, what matters to them, and how your solution creates meaningful change.

Use a six-frame storyboard below to structure the story.

2.1 Character

Who is this really for? Identify the ideal user with the most to gain.

Example: For Air New Zealand's SkyCouch, the character was long-haul parents with small children—not just any passenger.

2.2 Motivation

What do they feel, fear, or want? Choose an emotional, social, or functional insight.

Example: Wevorce recognized that divorcing parents feared harming their children emotionally.

2.3 Conflict

What's standing in their way? Frame it as a "How might we..." question.

Example: How might we help mobile executives feel more in control during nonstop workdays?

2.4 Aspiration

What change are they hoping for? Focus on the benefit from their perspective.

Example: I can stay informed, even in back-to-back meetings.

2.5 Plot

What are the 2–3 essential things the solution does to deliver the value?

Example: For Blackberry:

- Push email within 1 second
- Full-day battery life
- One-handed navigation

2.6 Setting

Where does this fit in the broader landscape?

Create a **simple 2x2 quadrant map** to show your position:

- Choose two defining attributes (e.g., automation vs. control).
- Label each axis from low to high.
- Plot your idea alongside alternatives.

Your goal: land in the upper right—strong on both axes.



Effective cleaning
Pleasant odor
Time saving

2.1 Character

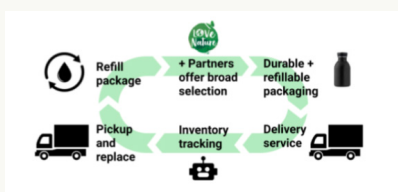
Nora is a mother of two teenagers and a consultant with various clients. She tends to work longer days to meet the demands of her clients. Her husband is traveling every other week, so she has an extra burden at home. Her teenage daughter has motivated her to be much more environmentally conscientious.

2.2 Motivation

As much as Nora would like to only have sustainable daily goods, she simply doesn't have the extra time that it would need to refill bottles and make her own cleaning products. Also, her experience with sustainable cleaning products is that they don't clean as well as she would like the smell isn't so pleasant.

2.3 Conflict

Nora needs a sustainable cleaning product, which is very effective at cleaning, leaves a pleasant odor, and which doesn't require her to make an extra effort to shop.



2.4 Aspiration

Make sustainable decisions enjoyable and carefree for everyone (not just hardcore environmentalists) in everyday situations.

2.5 Plot

The LoveNature shop:

- Provides a broad selection of sustainable products to cover all cleaning needs
- that are all effective at cleaning and appeal to consumers' aesthetics
- in a low-effort circular packaging solution that self-manages inventory

2.6 Setting

The competitors focus on the extremes. Either they optimize to be highly effective cleaning products with pleasant odors OR they are very sustainable. The highly effective products have the larger market share. Our opportunity is to be effective enough and be highly sustainable. We may not be as optimized as either of those categories, but we feel we have a good balance to fit into the lives of a large audience.

Step 3: Validate your Product Narrative

Before turning your Product Narrative into OKRs, make sure it resonates. Use lightweight prototypes to test for clarity, relevance, and strategic alignment, so you don't commit to weak or misaligned objectives.

How to Test Your Product Narrative

- **Prototype the Story**
Use a storyboard, prototype, or simple animatic to bring the narrative to life quickly and tangibly.
- **Get Fast Feedback**
Share it with target users and stakeholders. Ask:
 - **Is this clear and easy to follow?**
 - **Does it feel relevant and important?**
 - **Does it support our broader strategic goals?**
- **Refine with the Team**
Use a short Framestorming session or creative workshop to sharpen the best version of the story.
- **Run a Quick Validation Cycle**
Give yourself 1–2 weeks to gather feedback, iterate, and align on the version that will move forward.

A Validated OKR Story Should Be:

- **Clear** – The intended change is obvious and easy to explain
- **Resonant** – Users and stakeholders see the value and relevance
- **Strategic** – It supports your key business or product goals
- **Feasible** – Your team believes it can realistically be achieved

Keep a Record

Whether you use a shared doc, a slide deck, or a spreadsheet, make sure to document the final narrative and what was tested. That way, your team can track why the OKR exists and revisit the story during execution.

Step 4: Build OKRs from the Validated Product Narrative

Your Product Narrative expresses a clear vision, a meaningful change in the user's world. That vision becomes the foundation for your OKRs.

Rather than jumping straight to metrics, start by asking: What objectives would make this vision a reality? Use the story to guide your team in identifying what matters most and how to measure success.

From Narrative to OKRs

- **Vision:** The narrative frames why this work matters and what change it aims to create
- **Objectives:** Brainstorm up to three concrete goals that move the vision forward
- **Key Results:** Define up to three Key Results per Objective, which show how you will measure meaningful progress
- **Initiatives:** Identify projects or actions that will support the results

This is typically done in a collaborative session where the team works from the validated story to generate options and align on the most strategic direction.

Example:

Narrative Vision:

Enterprise users spend too much time on repetitive, manual processes. They want to focus on high-value work.

How it connects:

The narrative highlights wasted time and missed potential. The Objective addresses this by improving workflow efficiency.

Objective:

Increase operational efficiency for enterprise customers through automated workflows.

Key Results:

- Reduce manual data processing per client from 5 hours to 30 minutes
- Increase adoption of automated workflows from 40 percent to 85 percent
- Improve enterprise customer retention from 88 percent to 95 percent

Initiatives:

- Improve onboarding for workflow automation
- Train client success teams on new capabilities
- Launch analytics dashboard to track automation gains



MARKET VALIDATION PLAYBOOK

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Introduction

Most new products don't fail because the idea was bad. They fail because teams build too soon, with too much certainty and too little evidence.

In many organizations, progress is measured by output—features launched, prototypes built, timelines met. That creates pressure to do rather than to learn. Teams are rewarded for moving fast, not for slowing down to ask hard questions like:

- **Does anyone actually want this?**
- **Are they willing to give something up to get it?**

Even when teams want to validate early, they often don't know how. They fall back on stakeholder input, customer interviews, or internal business cases—none of which reflect **real-world behavior**. In some cases, teams avoid early validation altogether because it feels risky. What if the answer is “no”? What if we learn the idea won't work?

And ironically, validation is seen as expensive, while building the wrong thing is treated as normal.

That's where the Market Validation Framework comes in.

It gives product teams a clear, two-phase process to test the viability of an idea—before committing significant time and resources:

- **Phase 1: Interest Validation** – Do people engage, click, or show curiosity when they see the idea in the wild?
- **Phase 2: Commitment Validation** – Are they willing to exchange something valuable (money, time, reputation) to get it?

This is not a theoretical exercise. It's an evidence-based approach that relies on customer behavior, not opinions or promises. You gather fast, low-cost signals that help you decide what to build, how to price it, and whether it's worth building at all.

The result?

Less waste. Faster learning. Higher odds of building something people actually want.

Framework Objectives

1. Validate early interest before investing time and money
2. Confirm real commitment—not just curiosity
3. Learn fast by testing behavior, not asking opinions

Phase 1: Interest Validation

Key Question

Do people care enough to take action—even when they're not asked to commit?

This phase is about detecting early behavioral signals. You're not testing what people say they want—you're testing what they do when they encounter your idea.

Validation Methods

- **Fake Door Test** – Create a landing page or ad promoting the product with a sign-up or click-through button. Measure how many people engage, even if there's no product behind it yet.
- **Concierge MVP** – Manually deliver the product or service to early users. See if they continue using it despite imperfections.
- **Wizard of Oz Test** – Present a working interface, but fake the backend. You simulate functionality while observing usage patterns.
- **Referral Challenge** – Ask early users to refer friends to gain access. Referrals are a strong sign of enthusiasm and potential virality.
- **Behavioral Interviews** – Talk to users about what they've actually done to solve the problem, not what they hypothetically might do.

Success Criteria

- 5–10% conversion rate on a landing page (Fake Door)
- Users tolerate friction or manual processes (Concierge MVP)
- Organic referrals from initial users
- Clear alignment between user pain and your value proposition (from interviews)

Actionable Next Steps

- **If interest is validated** → move to Commitment Validation
- **If interest is weak** → refine your message, audience, or format
- **If interest is nonexistent** → pause, combine with another initiative, or kill the idea

Phase 2: Commitment Validation

Validation Methods

- **Deposit Test** – Ask for a small, refundable deposit. It's a low-friction way to test seriousness.
- **Pre-order / Paid Beta** – Charge users in advance, before the product is fully built. Prepayment is one of the strongest signals of demand.
- **Letter of Intent (LOI)** – For B2B, request signed commitments to purchase, even if non-binding.
- **Price Sensitivity Testing** – Offer multiple pricing tiers and observe what users choose. It reveals perceived value.
- **Bartering / Value Exchange** – Ask for something valuable—like user data, time, or referrals—in exchange for early access. If they're willing, it shows true commitment.

Success Criteria

- 5–10% of users pay or place deposits
- 10–20% of B2B leads sign LOIs
- Users opt for higher-priced tiers
- Customers exchange something that costs them—money, time, or reputation

Actionable Next Steps

- **If commitment is validated** → proceed to build, scale, or fundraise
- **If it's weak** → iterate on pricing, positioning, or business model
- **If no value is exchanged** → reassess or discontinue the initiative

Decision Pathways

- Market validation isn't a binary process.
Based on your findings, you can:
- **Proceed** – If both interest and commitment are validated
- **Refine** – If one phase is strong but the other is weak
- **Pause** – If timing or market conditions aren't right
- **Merge** – Combine with another initiative or offering
- **Kill** – If clear behavioral evidence shows insufficient traction

Why It Works

- **Prevents premature scaling** – Avoids over-building before validating
- **Behavior-first** – Focuses on action, not opinions
- **Accelerates learning** – Encourages rapid, low-risk testing
- **Enables better decisions** – Gives you more than a binary choice

How To Run the Validation Methods

The following section provides practical guidance for running each validation method. These are lightweight, fast, and accessible ways to gather real

Phase 1: Interest Validation Methods

Fake Door Test

Create a simple landing page or ad that promotes a product or feature as if it already exists. Include a clear call to

Concierge MVP

Deliver your product or service manually to a few users, without building any automation. Do the work behind the scenes—your goal is to see if they come back for more.

Example: Manually generate reports, send personalized advice, or fulfill requests over email.

Tip: Keep your initial users close—talk to them directly and improve based on their feedback.

Wizard of Oz Test

Build a front-end interface that looks real, but fake the backend logic. When users interact with it, you manually respond as if it's automated.

Example: A chatbot that's actually powered by a human behind the scenes.

Tools: Webflow, Glide, Bubble, Google Sheets

Tip: Use this to test UI, flows, and willingness to engage—before investing in automation.

Referral Challenge

Offer users something of value (early access, discounts, exclusive features) if they refer others. Track referral volume and engagement.

Example: “Invite 3 friends to get early access.”

Tools: Viral Loops, SparkLoop, simple Google Forms

Tip: A strong referral response is one of the

Behavioral Interviews

Interview users about **past behavior**, not opinions. Ask:

- When did you last face this problem?
- What did you do about it?
- What tools did you use?
- Avoid hypotheticals (“Would you use...”).

Tip: Listen for workarounds, DIY hacks, or tools they pay for—those are signs of

Phase 2:

Commitment Validation Methods

Deposit Test

Offer the product or service in the future and ask users to place a small, refundable deposit to reserve access.

Example: “Reserve your spot for \$10. Fully refundable.”

Tip: Keep the deposit small, but meaningful. This tests seriousness with minimal risk.

Pre-order / Paid Beta

Let users pay for the product before it’s built or fully launched. Make the timeline and offer transparent.

Example: “Buy now for 40% off—delivery in 6 weeks.”

Tip: Offer a guarantee or refund policy to reduce perceived risk. Even a few conversions are gold.

Letter of Intent (LOI)

In B2B, ask potential customers to sign a non-binding letter stating that they intend to buy if certain criteria are met.

Tip: Make the LOI as specific as possible—price range, volume, timeline. It doesn’t need to be legally binding to be useful.

Price Sensitivity Testing

Offer multiple pricing tiers and track what people choose—or A/B test different prices across users.

Example: “Basic \$10 / Pro \$25 / Premium \$50”

Tools: Stripe checkout pages, Google Forms, email surveys with fake options

Tip: Look for the skew: if most users pick the lowest tier, your perceived value may be too low.

Bartering / Value Exchange

If you can’t charge money yet, ask users to “pay” with something else meaningful: referrals, feedback, their time, or access to data.

Example: “Answer a 5-minute survey to get early access.”

Tip: Only count this as commitment if the cost is clear and non-trivial.

Conclusion

The Market Validation Framework helps you de-risk product development by focusing on **what people actually do**, not what they say. By validating both **interest** and **commitment**, you can confidently move forward with ideas that are wanted, valued, and grounded in real behavior.

Whether you're refining an early concept or launching a new venture, this framework helps ensure your next step is the right one.



THE SXD PRIORITIZATION METHOD

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Structured Approach for Project planning

The SxD (**Strategy by Design**) Prioritization Method is a structured approach that helps product teams decide what to build next. It balances foundational functionality, premium capabilities, and bold innovations. By aligning decisions with both business goals and customer needs, the method supports a more thoughtful and evidence-based approach to prioritization.

Even in situations driven by regulatory changes, utility delivery, or minimal scope, there is value in reframing the problem to consider customer needs, strategic alignment, and opportunities for differentiation. This does not mean always adding innovation or premium features, but it does mean asking whether there is a chance to create greater value than originally assumed.

Before You Prioritize

The SxD Prioritization Method is designed to help product teams prioritize the best ideas. It does not evaluate whether an idea is worth pursuing in the first place.

Before applying this method, we assume that each idea has already been validated to some degree. This might include customer discovery, market research, problem reframing, or early prototyping. First, confirm that the idea addresses a meaningful user and business need.

This methodology is not for deciding if an idea is good. It is for deciding which good ideas to build first.

The Three Dimensions of Prioritization

Instead of focusing only on must-have features, the SxD Prioritization Method encourages teams to consider a broader spectrum of value. It starts with customer value and balances this with business goals and the development effort required to deliver.

By combining customer value, business goal, and development effort, the SxD Prioritization Method empowers teams to:

1. **Prioritize a balanced portfolio of features** that includes essential functionality, enhancements that improve satisfaction, and innovative breakthroughs that drive differentiation.
2. **Make informed trade-offs** by weighing each feature's potential impact against the required effort.
3. **Optimize resource allocation** by focusing development time and investment where it delivers the greatest return.

This approach provides a practical and structured way to make prioritization decisions, helping teams build products that are more customer-centric, strategically aligned, and competitive in the market.

Methodology

The following sections outline how to apply the method in practice. Each step provides a clear action, a rationale, and any scoring or tools required

1. Identify and Define Features:

Before you prioritize, you need a clear and shared understanding of what you're prioritizing. This step is about surfacing the full range of potential features or improvements and framing them in a way that supports downstream evaluation.

Feature Exploration

Begin by gathering a broad list of potential features, ideas, and enhancements. Include different types of value, such as:

- Core functionality users expect
- Performance improvements that remove friction or add efficiency
- Differentiating innovations that set you apart

Sources may include customer feedback, competitor analysis, internal ideas, or insights from research.

Group into Value Propositions

To avoid getting lost in granular features, group related items under clear, user-facing **benefit statements**. For example:

Instead of listing “file upload,” “PDF export,” and “shareable links,” group them under: “Easily share reports with others.”

This makes it easier to evaluate the **outcome for the user**, not just the mechanism.

Key Output:

2. Assess Customer Value:

Customer value is the first and most important input into prioritization, and is assessed by combining qualitative categorization with a quantitative importance score.. This step evaluates how important each feature or benefit is from the user's perspective.

The SxD Prioritization Method uses two complementary approaches. The first is the Kano Model, which classifies how users emotionally respond to the presence or absence of a feature. The second is a 1–5 importance rating, which quantifies how much users care about the feature overall. Together, these methods provide both qualitative and quantitative insight into user needs.

Kano Classification (Focused Use)

For a selected subset of key features or benefits (typically 10–20), use the Kano Model to classify how users perceive each one. Table 1.

Importance Rating (1–5 Scale)

In parallel with Kano classification, ask users to rate the importance of each feature on a scale from 1 to 5.

- This score indicates how critical or desirable a feature is, independent of how it affects satisfaction.
- It helps distinguish between features that users appreciate (Kano) and features they truly value (importance).
- Responses can be averaged across users and used directly as the customer value input in prioritization scoring. The Kano category is used to interpret and segment features, but it does not affect the numerical score.

While Kano reveals how a feature drives satisfaction, the importance rating reveals how much it matters.

Note on Method Flexibility

While Kano and importance ratings are the preferred methods, the SxD Prioritization Method is modular. If your team already uses a different customer insight model (e.g., Jobs To Be Done, satisfaction scoring, or NPS driver analysis), you can adapt your results to fit the same three-tier framework shown above.

Tooling Limitation:

The included automation templates and survey tools are currently built for Kano-based workflows. If using another method, customer value categories will need to be mapped and entered manually.

Kano Category	Description	Examples
Must-Haves	Basic expectations that users demand	Login functionality, checkout flow
	Satisfaction increases as the feature improves	Faster page load times, better UX

Table 1:

How to Gather Input

We highly recommend conducting Kano surveys with customers. However, in early phases or where access is limited, teams may begin by surveying internal stakeholders as proxies, such as product managers, designers, or customer-facing staff. These internal responses should be treated as hypotheses and validated with real users as soon as possible.

You can gather data in three ways:

- **Customer Surveys** Use structured Kano questions (see below) with a small sample of representative users.
- **Internal Proxy Surveys** Use the same survey format with internal team members who are familiar with customer needs.
- **Follow-up Interviews and Usability Testing** Qualitative sessions help confirm how users think and feel, especially about unfamiliar or new-to-market features.

How a Kano Survey Works

Each feature is evaluated by asking two questions:

1. **Functional:** “How would you feel if this feature were present?”
2. **Dysfunctional:** “How would you feel if this feature were not present?”

For each, the respondent selects:

- I like it
- I expect it
- I am neutral
- I can tolerate it
- I dislike it

These answers are paired and interpreted using the Kano model to assign a category:

- **Must-Have**
- **Performance**
- **Delighter**
- (Occasionally: **Indifferent**, **Reverse**, or **Questionable**)

The Kano Model itself includes three additional technical categories used during analysis:

- **Indifferent** – The user doesn’t care whether the feature exists or not
- **Reverse** – The user actively dislikes the feature if it’s included
- **Questionable** – The user gave conflicting answers or misunderstood the question

These categories are part of the data-cleaning and interpretation process, not prioritization.

How to Handle These in Practice:

- **Indifferent:**
Usually deprioritized or dropped unless it's needed for internal reasons
- **Reverse:**
Strong signal that the feature might cause harm or confusion—requires follow-up
- **Questionable:**
These responses are usually discarded for that feature/participant

How to Interpret the Results

After collecting results from multiple respondents:

- Tally the responses for each feature
- Assign the feature to the category with the most responses
- Evaluate the strength of sentiment to determine a relative rank within its category

This process gives you both:

- A **Kano category** (Must-Have, Performance, or Delighter)
- A **relative rank** within that category, based on the intensity and consistency of user responses

You can record the result in this format:

<Feature>, <Category>, <Rank in Category>

e.g. Printing, Delighter, Rank 8

This format will be used in later steps to combine customer value with business alignment and development effort.

Key Output:

A categorized and ranked list of features based on user value perception. Each feature is labeled as a

3. Apply Business Goal Weighting:

Every organization has different strategic goals at different times—launching quickly, growing revenue, improving retention, or standing out in the market. These goals should influence how you allocate resources across different types of features.

In the SxD Prioritization Method, we use business goal weighting to guide how many features to select from each Kano category—Must-Haves, Performance Features, and Delighters—rather than adjusting individual feature scores.

This preserves the clarity of customer value (from Kano) while giving you flexibility to make portfolio-level trade-offs based on strategy.

Step-by-Step

1. Choose Your Strategic Goal(s)

Select a primary goal from the list:

- Speed to Market
- Product-Market Fit
- Competitive Differentiation
- Revenue Growth
- Enterprise Stability
- Operational Efficiency
- User Engagement & Retention
- Regulatory Compliance & Risk
- Ecosystem Growth

2. Apply Kano Category Weighting

Each business goal emphasizes certain types of features. The table below shows how much weight to give to each Kano category, depending on your current strategy. Table 2.

Key Output:

Business Goal	Must-Haves		Delighters
Speed to Market	0.6	0.3	0.1
Product-Market Fit	0.4	0.4	0.2
	0.2	0.3	0.5
Revenue Growth	0.3	0.4	0.3
Enterprise Stability	0.7	0.2	0.1
	0.6	0.3	0.1
User	0.3	0.4	0.3
Regulatory	0.8	0.2	0.0

Table 2:

4. Assess Development Effort:

Development effort is the third key factor in prioritization. While customer value and business alignment indicate desirability, this step evaluates feasibility and cost. It ensures that high-impact ideas are achievable within your resource constraints.

Step-by-Step:

1. Estimate Effort for Each Feature

For every feature or benefit, estimate the level of development effort required. Consider:

- Technical Feasibility – How complex is the solution from an engineering perspective?
- Resource Requirements – How much time, budget, and personnel will this demand?
- Integration Complexity – Will this feature require changes to infrastructure or dependencies?
- Potential Risks – Are there uncertainties, unknowns, or potential blockers?

2. Assign a T-Shirt Size

Use a T-shirt sizing scale to make effort estimations easier for teams. Table 3.

T-Shirt Size	Description	Effort Score
XS	Trivial work, almost no risk	1
S	Small, familiar work	2
M	Moderate effort, low risk	4
L	Large scope, moderate risk	6
XL		8

Table 3:

5. Prioritize Features:

Every organization has different strategic goals. With Impact (Customer Value), Business Goal, and Effort scores assigned, it's time to translate those inputs into a draft prioritization. Rather than producing one master list that ignores context or three isolated lists that are hard to compare, this step creates a structured ranking that teams can refine through discussion.

Step-by-Step:

Step 1: Calculate a Prioritization Score Using Importance

To generate a draft prioritization score, combine three factors: customer value, business goal alignment, and development effort.

Use the following formula:

Prioritization Score = (Importance Score × Business Goal Fit) / Effort

- Importance Score reflects how much users care about a feature, based on a 1–5 rating collected during the customer value assessment phase. This serves as the numerical representation of customer value.
- Business Goal Fit is the strategic weighting assigned in Step 3, based on your organization's current focus.
- Effort is the estimated implementation cost from Step 4, on a 1–10 scale.

This formula ensures that prioritization reflects what matters most to users, aligns with strategic intent, and accounts for the cost of delivery.

Step 2: Apply MoSCoW Classification

Sort all features by Prioritization Score (highest to lowest). Then divide them into four bands:

- Must – Top 25%
- Should – Next 25%
- Could – Next 25%
- Won't (for now) – Bottom 25%

These classifications help teams quickly see what to prioritize, debate edge cases, and align on trade-offs.

Use the Score as a Starting Point, Not the Final Word

The prioritization score offers a rational starting point for conversation, but it doesn't replace judgment. Teams are encouraged to adjust classifications based on new insights, dependencies, or changes in strategy.

Step 3: Regroup by Kano Category

Once all features have been scored and ranked, regroup them by their Kano category — Must-Have, Performance, or Delighter. This step is not about recalculating priority, but about understanding the composition of your roadmap.

Review the distribution of features across categories and use it to guide conversations about product balance. For example:

- Do we have enough Delighters to surprise users?
- Are too many Performance features crowding out foundational needs?
- Are we overloading the roadmap with Must-Haves that may not differentiate us?

Kano helps teams maintain the right mix of feature types. While it doesn't affect the numerical prioritization score, it plays a key role in shaping a balanced and strategically aligned product portfolio.

Step 4: Decide Portfolio Mix

Key Output:

Use your business strategy and available capacity to decide:

- How many Must-Haves are required
- Which Performance Features to invest in
- Which Delighters will elevate the experience

Step 5: Use Effort Scores for Implementation Planning

After features are prioritized, effort scores can also help define implementation levels. Table 4.

Priority Score Range	Effort Level	Implementation Focus
8 – 10	Robust	Fully optimized, secure, scalable
5 – 7.9		

Table 4:

6. Regular Review and Adjustments:

- **Monitor Progress:** Regularly review progress against the prioritized roadmap.
- **Gather Feedback:** Continuously gather feedback from customers and stakeholders.
- **Adjust Priorities:** Re-evaluate and adjust priorities based on new data, changing market conditions, and evolving customer needs.

Key Output:

By following this structured methodology, product teams can make informed and data-driven decisions about feature prioritization, ensuring that they develop products that are not only functional but also customer-centric, innovative, and strategically aligned for long-term success.

Why?

- Priorities shift over time based on new customer insights, technology, and business constraints.

How?

- Establish quarterly review cycles:
 - Collect new customer feedback.
 - Reassess effort estimates (refined in sprint planning).
 - Adjust feature prioritization based on real-world learnings.

Automation and Templates

Step	What Can Be Automated?	Tool/Method
Kano Categorization	Automated Kano Survey Tool	Google Forms, Notion, Custom API
Scoring Calculation	Auto-score features based on formula	Google Sheets, Notion Database
Effort Level Assignment		Google Sheets Script

Table 5:

Kano Questionnaire Structure per Feature

For **each feature or benefit**, use:

1. Title + Description block (for context)

- **Title:** Feature Name
- **Description:** Short, user-facing explanation of the benefit

2. Question 1

- **Title:** How would you feel if this feature were present?
- **Type:** Dropdown
- **Options:**
 - I like it
 - I expect it
 - I am neutral
 - I can tolerate it
 - I dislike it

3. Question 2

- **Title:** How would you feel if this feature were not present?
- **Type:** Dropdown
- **Same 5 options**

Example Entry

Feature: Progress Tracker

Description: Users can see how far they've come in completing their tasks or learning modules.

- **Q1:** How would you feel if this feature were present? (dropdown)
- **Q2:** How would you feel if this feature were not present?(dropdown)

Example Features/Benefits and Descriptions

You can copy-paste these into your form:

1. **Dark Mode** Allows users to switch the interface to a darker color scheme to reduce eye strain.
2. **Progress Tracker** Lets users view how much of a task or course they've completed.
3. **Real-Time Collaboration** Enables multiple users to work on the same document or task at the same time.
4. **Offline Access** Allows access to key features even without an internet connection.
5. **Quick Search Bar** Provides instant search across all content within the application.
6. **Task Reminders** Sends automated alerts to help users remember upcoming tasks or deadlines.
7. **Saved Views** Lets users save custom filters or dashboard settings for easy access.
8. **One-Click Export** Enables users to export data or reports with a single click.
9. **Mobile App** Offers a native mobile experience for accessing the platform on the go.
10. **Voice Input** Allows users to dictate content or commands instead of typing.
11. **Smart Suggestions** Suggests next actions or content based on user behavior.
12. **Live Chat Support** Provides direct access to support agents via chat during business hours.

- 13. Visual Analytics Dashboard** Displays data in charts and graphs to help users spot trends and insights.
- 14. Drag-and-Drop Interface** Makes it easy to reorder or organize items with simple gestures.
- 15. Biometric Login** Enables users to log in using fingerprint or face recognition.
- 16. Multilingual Support** Allows users to switch the interface language.
- 17. Undo/Redo Actions** Lets users revert or repeat recent changes.
- 18. Keyboard Shortcuts** Enables power users to navigate faster using hotkeys.
- 19. Personalized Onboarding** Tailors the onboarding flow to the user's goals and role.
- 20. Accessibility Mode** Improves usability for screen readers and users with motor impairments.

Potential Future Development

Feature Enhancements

- **Filters & Toggles** Enable scenario-based views (e.g. for different business goals, product lines, or user segments).
- **Export & Sharing**
 - Generate polished **PDFs or slide visuals** for stakeholder communication
 - Export to **CSV** for data portability
- **Roadmap Integration** Sync or link prioritized items into a product backlog or roadmap tool.
- **Collaboration Support**
 - Multi-user access with role-based permissions
 - In-line comments or approvals
- **Advanced Views**
 - **Dynamic filtering and sorting**
 - **Saved views** for recurring stakeholder needs (e.g. MVP filter, quarterly goals)
- **Platform Integrations** Connect with tools like **Jira**, **Linear**, **Notion**, or internal systems to sync feature lists and statuses.
- **Extended Feature Coverage**
 - Support for large-scale feature sets beyond 20 items
 - Ability to segment surveys by user role, workflow, or product module
 - Optional randomization or rotation of features across respondents
 - Multi-phase survey support to allow broad initial screening followed by focused validation

Value of Spreadsheet-First Approach

By working in the spreadsheet, we will:

- **Validate logic in the real world** before investing in code
- **Identify reusable inputs** that could benefit from templating
- **Spot UI friction** where automation or better UX is needed
- **Observe common customizations** to inform abstraction and systematization, and find common tweaks per project (and what could be abstracted)
- In-line comments or approvals





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